

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 10

Introduction to I'raab · Raf', Nasb and Jarr

1. The I'raab of the Ism

I'raab is the most important characteristic of Arabic and belongs to Arabic alone. Its literal meaning is **to make Arabic** and **to make manifest**. The change that occurs in the state or shape of a noun without any change in its meaning is called a change of *I'raab*.

The technical definition: *I'raab* means the **letter or harakah** through which a change occurs at the end of a *mu'rab* word. Thus the single word Zayd appears in three forms: لَقِيتُ، أَفْشَى زَيْدٌ سَرِيٌّ، نَظَرْتُ إِلَى زَيْدٍ، زَيْدًا — a dammah, a fathah and a kasrah appearing at the end.

The final letter of an *Ism Mu'rab* upon which the *I'raab* falls is called the *Mahall ul I'raab*. In نَحَجَ زَيْدٌ فِي الْإِمْتِحَانِ، the daal of Zayd is the *Mahall ul I'raab*, since the *I'raab* appears upon it.

Why knowing the I'raab of a noun matters

Knowing the *I'raab* of a noun reveals its role in the sentence — what it has come as, and why its state is changing. It is the *I'raab* that tells us whether a given noun is the *Fa'il*, the *Maf'ul*, or something following a *Harf ul Jarr*.

2. The difference between I'raab and Harakaat

Arabic has three basic vowels: *kasrah* (zer), *fathah* (zabar) and *dammah* (pesh). The doubled vowels َ، ِ، ُ are called *Tanween* — *dammatayn*, *fathatayn* and *kasratayn*.

I'raab, by contrast, means the change that occurs in the **final letter** of a word or noun. That change may take the form of a *harakah* (zabar, zer, pesh) or of a letter (alif, waw, yaa'), as in مُسَلِّمٌ، مُسَلِّمًا، مُسَلِّمٌ.

Whenever a noun is used in an Arabic sentence or passage, it stands in some particular state according to its role, and it is the changing of that state which alters the shape or vowel at the end of the word.

A difference of terminology: *Dammah*, *fathah* and *kasrah* are generally applied to the vowels of *mabni* words, whereas *raf'*, *nasb* and *jarr* are applied to the *I'raab* of *mu'rab* words. In other words, *raf'*, *nasb* and *jarr* belong to the *harakaat* and letters of *i'raab*, while *damm*, *fath* and *kasr* belong to the *harakaat* of *bina'*.

3. The three states of the Ism by I'raab

By *I'raab* a noun has three states:

State	English term	What the noun is called	Mark
Halat ur Raf'	1st Form	Marfoo'	(two pesh) َ
Halat un Nasb	2nd Form	Mansoob	(two zabar) ِ
Halat ul Jarr	3rd Form	Majroor	(two zer) ِ

There is a fourth state, *jazm*, meaning the absence of a vowel, and a word upon which it falls is called *majzoom*. But this state does not occur in nouns; it belongs only to verbs.

4. I'raab bil Harakah and I'raab bil Harf

The *I'raab* of singular masculine and feminine nouns and of the *Jam' Mukassar* changes through *harakaat*, whereas the *I'raab* of the *Tathniyah* and the *Jam' Salim* changes through *letters*, that is, it is recognised by sound.

Kind	Definition	Example
I'raab bil Harakah	An I'raab that takes the form of a zabar, zer or pesh, or of two zabar, two zer or two pesh	جاءَ الرَّجُلُ ، رَأَيْتُ الرَّجُلَ
I'raab bil Harf	An I'raab that takes the form of a waw, an alif or a yaa'	جاءَ أَبُوكَ ، رَأَيْتُ أَبَاكَ

5. The I'raab of singular masculine and feminine nouns

Singular masculine and feminine nouns are *Marfoo'* with two pesh on the final letter, *Mansoob* with two zabar, and *Majroor* with two zer.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
وَلَدٌ	وَلَدًا	وَلَدٍ
رَسُولٌ	رَسُولًا	رَسُولٍ
بِنْتُ	بِنْتًا	بِنْتٍ
أُخْتُ	أُخْتًا	أُخْتٍ

6. The rules for writing the alif in the state of Nasb

In the *Mansoob* form an alif is written along with the two zabar. This is the general rule, but it does not apply to two kinds of noun.

First exception: nouns ending in a round ة

Nouns that end in a *Taa' Marbutah*, the round ة, take only the two zabar in the state of *nasb*; no alif is written.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
جَنَّةٌ	جَنَّةً	جَنَّةٍ
صَالِحَةٌ	صَالِحَةً	صَالِحَةٍ
كَلِمَةٌ	كَلِمَةً	كَلِمَةٍ

Second exception: nouns with an alif before the hamzah

Nouns that end in a hamzah preceded by an alif likewise take only the two zabar in the state of *nasb*; no alif is written.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
سَمَاءٌ	سَمَاءً	سَمَاءٍ
جَزَاءٌ	جَزَاءً	جَزَاءٍ
دُعَاءٌ	دُعَاءً	دُعَاءٍ

When there is no alif before the hamzah

Nouns ending in a bare hamzah with no alif before it do take an added alif after the *Tanween* in the state of *nasb*.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
جُزْءٌ	جُزْءًا	جُزْءٍ
سُوءٌ	سُوءًا	سُوءٍ
شَيْءٌ	شَيْئًا	شَيْئٍ

The word شَيْءٌ is also written as شَيْئًا.

7. The I'raab of the Jam' Mukassar

The *I'raab* of a *Jam' Mukassar* is exactly like that of a singular noun: *Marfoo'* with two pesh on the final letter, *Mansoob* with two zabar, and *Majroor* with two zer, and an alif is written along with the two zabar in the *Mansoob* form.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
أَزْوَاجٌ	أَزْوَاجًا	أَزْوَاجٍ
أَقْلَامٌ	أَقْلَامًا	أَقْلَامٍ
أَوْلَادٌ	أَوْلَادًا	أَوْلَادٍ

8. When al- enters the noun

Rule: When ال enters an indefinite singular or a *Jam' Mukassar*, masculine or feminine, the *Tanween* at its end falls away, because ال and *Tanween* cannot come together on one noun.

- الْكِتَابُ → كِتَابٌ
- الْمُسْلِمُ → مُسْلِمٌ
- الْمُسْلِمَةُ → مُسْلِمَةٌ
- الْأَعْمَالُ → أَعْمَالٌ

With **اَلْ** present, the *Mansoob* form takes a single zabar and no alif is written with it.

Marfoo'	Mansoob	Majroor
الرَّجُلُ	الرَّجُلَ	الرَّجُلِ
الْجَنَّةُ	الْجَنَّةَ	الْجَنَّةِ
الْأَعْمَالُ	الْأَعْمَالَ	الْأَعْمَالِ

9. The three kinds of I'raab

With respect to whether it is manifest or not, *I'raab* is of three kinds: *I'raab Asli*, *I'raab Far'i* and *I'raab Taqdeeri*.

9.1 I'raab Asli

Definition: *I'raab Asli* is the *I'raab* that appears through the original vowels, the *harakaat thalathah*, or through the known letters — that is, an *I'raab* that the tongue can utter with ease. These are three: *dammah* (pesh), *fathah* (zabar) and *kasrah* (zer).

For instance, the *dammah* in **جَاءَ الرَّجُلُ**, the *fathah* in **رَأَيْتُ الرَّجُلَ**, and the *kasrah* in **مَرَرْتُ بِالرَّجُلِ** are all *I'raab Asli*.

9.2 I'raab Far'i

Definition: *I'raab Far'i* is the *I'raab* in which letters (such as waw, yaa' or alif) or other vowels (such as a fathah in place of a dammah) stand in for the original vowels of pesh, zabar and zer.

Kind	Raf'	Nasb	Jarr	Example
1. Asma' Sittah Mukabbarah	waw	alif	yaa'	جَاءَ أَبُوكَ / رَأَيْتُ أَبَاكَ / مَرَرْتُ بِأَبِيكَ
2. Tathniyah	alif + noon	yaa' + noon	yaa' + noon	زَيْدَانِ / زَيْدَيْنِ
3. Jam' Mudhakkar Salim	waw + noon	yaa' + noon	yaa' + noon	زَيْدُونَ / زَيْدَيْنِ
4. Jam' Mu'annath Salim	dammah	kasrah	kasrah	مُسْلِمَاتُ / رَأَيْتُ مُسْلِمَاتٍ
5. Ghayr Munsarif nouns	dammah	fathah	fathah	جَاءَ أَحْمَدُ / مَرَرْتُ بِأَحْمَدَ
6. Af'al Khamsah	the noon stays	the noon drops	the noon drops	يَفْعَلُونَ / لَنْ يَفْعَلُوا

- The *Asma' Sittah* are these six nouns: أَبْ ، أَخْ ، حَمْ ، فَمْ ، هَنْ ، دُوْ . In them letters take the place of vowels as the *I'raab*.
- The *nasb* of the *Jam' Mu'annath Salim* is with a *kasrah*, as in رَأَيْتُ مُسْلِمَاتٍ — that is, a *kasrah* stands in for the *fathah*, and this is one form of *I'raab Far'i*.
- The *jarr* of a *Ghayr Munsarif* noun is with a *fathah*, and it accepts neither a *kasrah* nor a *Tanween*, as in مَرَرْتُ بِأَحْمَدَ.
- In the *Afal Khamsah* the noon remains in the state of *raf'*, as in يَفْعَلُونَ , and drops in *nasb* and *jazm*, as in لَنْ يَفْعَلُوا .

9.3 I'raab Taqdeeri

Definition: *I'raab Taqdeeri* is the *I'raab* that does not appear on the tongue but is supposed or assumed, there being always some impediment or cause preventing its appearance. Its opposite is *I'raab Lafzi*, which does appear in the words, as the *I'raab* of Zayd does in رِيحٌ زَيْدٌ فِي

تِجَارَتِهِ.

In the Qur'anic example كَلَّمَ اللَّهُ مُوسَى , the *I'raab* of the word Musa is *taqdeeri*, since it does not appear in the word.

The three principal cases of I'raab Taqdeeri

Kind	In which states it is taqdeeri	The cause	Examples
Ism Maqsur	All three — raf', nasb and jarr	Ta'adhdhur	مُوسَى ، عِيسَى ، هُذَى
Ism Manqus	Only raf' and jarr	Thiqal	الْقَاضِي ، الدَّاعِي
Mudaf ila Yaa' il Mutakallim	All three — raf', nasb and jarr	Munasabah	عُلَامِي ، كِتَابِي

- An *Ism Maqsur* is a noun ending in an *Alif Maqsurah*. All three *I'raab* upon it are supposed, because no *harakah* can appear on an alif at all. This impediment is called *ta'adhdhur*.
- An *Ism Manqus* is a noun ending in a yaa' preceded by a kasrah. Its *raf'* and *jarr* are supposed, as in جَاءَ الْقَاضِي and مَرَرْتُ بِالْقَاضِي , because sounding a dammah or a kasrah on a yaa' is heavy. This is called *thiqal*. Its *nasb*, however, is *lafzi* and manifest, since a fathah is light, as in رَأَيْتُ الْقَاضِي .

- A *Mudaf ila Yaa' il Mutakallim* is a noun with the yaa' of the speaker joined to its end. All its *I'raab* too are supposed, because the *yaa' ul mutakallim* compels the letter before it always to take a kasrah, so the original vowel cannot appear.

The difference in brief: *I'raab Asli* appears on the tongue and comes through the original vowel itself. *I'raab Far'i* also appears, but a letter or some other vowel stands in for the original one. And *I'raab Taqdeer* does not appear at all; it is assumed because of some cause.

10. Analysis of the verses of Surah al-Ghashiyah

هَلْ أَتَاكَ حَدِيثُ الْغَاشِيَةِ * وَجُوهٌ يَوْمَئِذٍ خَاشِعَةٌ * عَامِلَةٌ نَّاصِبَةٌ * تَصَلَّى نَارًا حَامِيَةً * تُسْقَى مِنْ عَيْنٍ آنِيَةٍ * لَيْسَ لَهُمْ طَعَامٌ إِلَّا مِنْ ضَرِيعٍ * لَا يَسْمِنُ وَلَا يُغْنِي مِنْ جُوعٍ *

(Surah al-Ghashiyah: 1 to 7)

These seven verses contain twelve nouns. Of them only one is *Ma'rifah*, namely الْغَاشِيَةِ, and all the rest are *Nakirah*. Likewise only one is a plural, namely وَجُوهٌ, and all the rest are singular.

Noun	I'raab	Wus'at	'Adad
حَدِيثُ	Marfoo'	Ma'rifah (Mudaf)	Wahid
الْغَاشِيَةِ	Majroor	Ma'rifah	Wahid
وَجُوهٌ	Marfoo'	Nakirah	Jam' Mukassar
خَاشِعَةٌ	Marfoo'	Nakirah	Wahid
نَارًا	Mansoob	Nakirah	Wahid
حَامِيَةً	Mansoob	Nakirah	Wahid
عَيْنٍ	Majroor	Nakirah	Wahid
آنِيَةٍ	Majroor	Nakirah	Wahid
طَعَامٌ	Marfoo'	Nakirah	Wahid
ضَرِيعٍ	Majroor	Nakirah	Wahid
جُوعٍ	Majroor	Nakirah	Wahid

A point worth noticing: نَارًا and حَامِيَةً are both *Mansoob*, yet an alif is written with the first and not with the second — because the second ends in a round ة. Similarly عَيْنِ, ضَرِيعِ and جُوعِ are *Majroor* because they follow the *Harful Jarr* مِنْ.

Summary

1. I'raab is the most important characteristic of Arabic and belongs to Arabic alone. Its literal meaning is to make Arabic and to make manifest.
2. Technically, I'raab is the letter or harakah through which a change occurs at the end of a mu'rab word.
3. The final letter of an Ism Mu'rab upon which the I'raab falls is called the Mahall ul I'raab.
4. I'raab reveals the role of a noun in a sentence — whether it is the Fa'il, the Ma'ful, or something following a Harf ul Jarr.
5. Harakaat can fall on any letter of a word, whereas I'raab is only the change of the final letter.
6. Dammah, fathah and kasrah belong to mabni words, while raf', nasb and jarr belong to mu'rab words.
7. By I'raab a noun has three states: raf' (Marfoo'), nasb (Mansoob) and jarr (Majroor). The fourth state, jazm, belongs to verbs only.
8. The I'raab of singular nouns and of the Jam' Mukassar changes through harakaat, while that of the Tathniyah and Jam' Salim changes through letters.
9. Singular nouns and the Jam' Mukassar are Marfoo' with two pesh, Mansoob with two zabar and Majroor with two zer.
10. In the Mansoob state an alif is written with the two zabar, except in nouns ending in a round ة and in those with an alif before the hamzah.
11. Nouns ending in a bare hamzah with no alif before it do take an added alif, as in شَيْءًا.
12. When al- enters a noun the Tanween falls away, and in the Mansoob state no alif is written either.
13. By whether it is manifest, I'raab is of three kinds: Asli, Far'i and Taqdeeri.
14. I'raab Asli appears through the original harakaat thalathah and is easily uttered by the tongue.
15. I'raab Far'i is that in which letters or other vowels stand in for the original vowels.
16. I'raab Far'i has six cases: the Asma' Sittah, the Tathniyah, the Jam' Mudhakkar Salim, the Jam' Mu'annath Salim, the Ghayr Munsarif, and the Af'al Khamsah.
17. The nasb of the Jam' Mu'annath Salim is with a kasrah, and the jarr of a Ghayr Munsarif with a fathah.
18. In the Af'al Khamsah the mark of raf' is the retention of the noon and the mark of nasb and jazm is its dropping.
19. I'raab Taqdeeri does not appear on the tongue but is assumed for some cause. Its opposite is I'raab Lafzi.
20. In an Ism Maqsur all three I'raab are taqdeeri because of ta'adhdhur, as in هُدًى and مُؤَسِّلًى.
21. In an Ism Manqus the raf' and jarr are taqdeeri because of thiqal, while the nasb is lafzi because a fathah is light.

22. In a Mudaf ila Yaa' il Mutakallim all three I'raab are taqdeeri, because the yaa' ul mutakallim compels a kasrah on the preceding letter.

Exercise

1. Give the literal and technical meanings of I'raab, and explain the Mahall ul I'raab.
2. Explain the difference between I'raab and harakaat with examples.
3. Write the three states of a noun by I'raab and the name given to the noun in each.
4. Explain the difference between I'raab bil Harakah and I'raab bil Harf with an example.
5. Write all three states of the following: وَلَدٌ , بِنْتُ , رَسُولٌ.
6. When is an alif written in the state of nasb and when is it not? Write all three cases with examples.
7. What two changes occur in the I'raab of a noun when al- enters it?
8. Give the definitions of I'raab Asli, Far'i and Taqdeeri.
9. Set out the six cases of I'raab Far'i in the form of a table.
10. Which are the Asma' Sittah? Explain all three of their states through one example.
11. What is distinctive about the I'raab of the Jam' Mu'annath Salim and of the Ghayr Munsarif?
12. Write all three cases of I'raab Taqdeeri together with their causes.
13. Why is the nasb of an Ism Manqus lafzi while its raf' and jarr are taqdeeri?
14. Take five nouns from the first seven verses of Surah al-Ghashiyah and write the I'raab of each.

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ